emergence on the international scene as countries with intensifying capitalist relations translates into a very different historical process than that considered 'normal'. This process has been defined by a key certainty, hidden under 'pedagogical' or 'missionary' discourse, that the expansion of capitalism responds to a certain quality intrinsic to some countries/peoples (racial characteristics, history, customs, language, spirit of initiative, education and so on).[1] From the perspective of many intellectuals of late or very late capitalist countries, the assumption was that dominant nations jealously guarded their 'advances' for themselves, subjugating the rest and impeding or delaying capitalist expansion.

From this argument emerged three strategic patterns for subordinate countries which preserve contact among themselves: the first was based on the study of development 'models,' copying (or adjusting) them, in an attempt to repeat a similar trajectory. Some more radical intellectuals proposed the need for national autonomy to get out from under the yoke imposed by the dominant countries (those indeed considered autonomous), to be followed by the development of their own capitalism. The second strategy aimed at adjusting to the yoke, at incorporating the pedagogy of co-sharing in eventual benefits through the classical political-economy formula of 'comparative advantages'. Even among the most integrated intellectuals, this option left lingering doubts over the input/extent of such 'benefits' as well as over the correctness of the thesis with its explicit purpose of safeguarding the international status quo. The third revolutionary strategy involved a complete break with the capitalist dynamic and the construction of a new economic and political organisation facilitating another type of social relations. For different reasons, several of its proponents came at times close to the more radical exponents of the first strategy.

This chapter's underlying thesis – capital-imperialism (Fontes 2012) – seeks to grasp its historical process by means of the contradictions inherent in the spread of capitalism. Such contradictions result as much from its protagonists' desires and plans as from the collisions and struggles between radically different domestic projects in each country (and among countries), taking into consideration that they do not happen in a vacuum but in the context of dominant capitalist social relations whose central characteristic is to expand, not just economically. Besides presenting a historical analysis, the chapter discloses some of capital-imperialism's characteristics, which in our opinion helps to get a better measure of the BRICS 'emergence'. It emphasises some of the contemporary tensions that the mere existence of BRICS definitely tends to exacerbate.

We do not endorse the idea of a quantifiable and accountable 'economics', separate from the rest of existence, which expresses human rationality.[2] Neither